

Keep the **color scheme** of the nursery fairly neutral and use pictures, accessories, and wall-hangings to **add color and fun**, since they are easiest to change as your baby grows.

**Q** We're starting to plan the nursery now. What do we need to think about first?

If you are planning to refurbish a room to turn it into a nursery, take the time now to research and buy appropriate lighting and chemical-free paints, since there is no immediate rush. The best and safest place for your baby to sleep for the first six months is in a bassinet or crib in the same room as you, to help reduce the risk of sudden infant death syndrome (SIDS) (see p.287). So you won't need a fully functioning nursery the moment your baby arrives home. Having said that, it's best to paint the room at least two to three months before your baby moves into it so you can air the room. Avoid using any paints that give off potentially harmful paint fumes and choose a brand that is free from harmful chemicals and toxins. Look for information that stipulates the paint has low, or zero, VOC levels. Volatile organic compounds, or VOCs, are gases found in products such as household paints that emit harmful chemicals.

Think, also, about the nursery lighting. A nightlight and/or dimmer switch will stop you and your partner from stumbling around in the dark during nighttime feedings, diaper changes, and midnight comforting sessions. And for many parents, blackout blinds are a must, ensuring that a baby isn't nudged out of sleep by early morning sunlight, especially in summer.

**Q** We have been offered a secondhand crib. Should we buy a new mattress?

**A new mattress is best.** This is because there is evidence that a mattress that isn't in the best condition can increase the potential risk of sudden infant death syndrome (SIDS), or crib

**Q** How do we make sure the nursery is a safe space?

You should think first about the layout of your baby's room and the most appropriate place to position the crib, and then arrange the rest of the furniture and equipment accordingly.

Avoid placing your baby's crib near a window or any area where it will get hit by direct sunlight, and make sure that it isn't next to any curtain cords or pulls that your baby could get tangled up in. And once your baby starts to pull himself up to standing, you will need to make sure that there are no pieces of

furniture near his crib that he could climb onto, or shelves that he could pull things off. Make sure that all the furniture is sturdy, or well anchored to the wall, so your baby won't be able to pull anything on top of himself. A plain wood floor is ideal, since it is easy to keep clean and dust free.

### NURSERY SAFETY ESSENTIALS

Run through these safety essentials to check that everything is in order before you move your baby into the room.



» **Temperature:** keep the room at an even temperature and make sure that it doesn't get too hot. Use a room thermometer to keep the temperature at a constant 64° F (18° C).



» **Baby monitor:** situate a baby monitor, if you use one, well out of your baby's reach, but close enough to his crib so that you can hear him immediately if he cries or seems to be distressed.



» **Smoke alarm:** you may also want to consider installing a carbon monoxide detector in or near your baby's room to prevent carbon monoxide poisoning, which has no outward signs.



» **Hazards:** make sure there are no cords, pulls, toys, or decorations such as a hanging mobile so close to the crib that your baby could get tangled in them. Secure any rugs to the floor with double-sided tape so that no one can slip on them.

You can make it easier to control your baby's **temperature** as he sleeps by choosing **cotton sheets** and **lightweight cotton baby blankets** for his bedding so you can **add or remove layers** if he is too hot or cold.

death, which usually occurs during sleep. When choosing a new mattress, look for firmness and breathable covers that can be removed and washed. The least expensive are foam mattresses, which may come with a waterproof covering, but have the least longevity and lose their shape most quickly. Coiled spring interior mattresses are better since they have inner springs sandwiched between layers of felt or

foam to offer sturdy support. Coir (coconut fiber) or other natural fiber mattresses are the firmest, most durable, and more expensive. Hypoallergenic mattresses have a removable quilted top layer that can be washed at a high temperature to remove any dust mites. Also, importantly, be sure the crib was manufactured after June 28, 2011, so it conforms to current safety standards.